

Making Cooperative Learning Work

I found a few articles on program reviews and accountability. What they all have in common is a set of methods for assessing the effects of their programs. It's really all about program effectiveness. Is the program successful? Is the assessment showing good results? The means of measuring program effectiveness are either empirical findings from research or program assessments. So, the difference lies in the person conducting the research. Like the article by "UCLA Community College Review: Performance Indicators and Performance-Based Funding in Community Colleges, Spring 2004, Vol. 31 Issue 4", it's strictly based on quantitative research, whereas the effectiveness of the deaf program is based on program reviews and assessments--this form of research is quantitative. I just wanted to provide some input on this topic as it relates to my posting today.

Anyway, I found two other articles that I particularly like: 1) We Are Teaching, But Are They Learning: Accountability, Productivity, and Assessment (by Patricia Iannuzzi, 1999); 2) Making Cooperative Learning Work (David W. Johnson, 1999). Both articles have reminded me of Joe's presentation in class, and it's in line with our current topic on leadership. I could not decide which one to post. Like, we don't have enough to read already, but I just want to put it out there, so if you have time, I will invite you to take a look.

Article: Making Cooperative Learning Work. By: Johnson, David W.; Johnson, Roger T. Theory into Practice, Spring99, Vol. 38 Issue 2, p67, 7p, 1 diagram; (AN 1883978)

This is very similar to Joe McLaughlin's presentation. From Joe's examples on collaborating, cooperating, coordinating, and networking, there is still a lot to discuss on this topic. I want to fuel more discussion by utilizing this article. To be a leader and a better decision-maker, one needs many perspectives, research, and experience. This article provides realistic theories and practices for program assessment, reviews, and "making cooperative learning work". If the purpose of education is the student learning outcome, then it's really about the effectiveness of the learning environment, institutional, faculty, employee, and student. At each level of the institution, assessments and reviews are a must, but knowing how to conduct effective assessments or research is equally important. What we don't need is to have extra data to review or unnecessary programs for assessment. This article is not only about the importance of cooperation but also about recognizing its types. Something to think about: recognizing what is and isn't a cooperative effort, and the types of cooperation. Now, if you are thinking about Joe's presentation, it makes a lot of sense. I'll leave you with the basic elements of cooperation (pg. 4, 70)

- 1) Positive interdependence
- 2) Individual accountability
- 3) Face-to-face promotive interaction
- 4) Social skills
- 5) Group processing

How do changing student demographics impact the practices of leadership and the strategies that are most likely to produce positive student learning? Along with many qualities of a good leader, cultural competency is also essential, and its elements three and four above--it may be all five elements. From student-to-student, faculty-to-student, faculty-to-faculty, and faculty-to-administration cooperation, all are well in play with mutual understanding and respect for each other. It's about responsibility, accountability, and caring.

What role do program review and /or accountability play in these strategies? Student plays your role as a student. Faculty plays your role as a teacher who is responsible and accountable. The administrator plays your role as a leader and manager — your decision-making is a mutual decision among all people involved. The five elements are also applied here.